

CHAPTER 17

Breaking Tasks Into Steps



THE DECOMPOSITION SKILL The most important skill in multi-step AI work is not writing better prompts. It is breaking tasks into the right stages.

A well-decomposed task has stages that:

Have distinct deliverables Can be reviewed independently Build on each other in a clear sequence Are each achievable to a high standard in a single focused interaction

Poorly decomposed tasks break in the wrong places, create dependencies that are hard to manage, or duplicate work across stages.

This chapter teaches the decomposition patterns that work most reliably across common professional tasks.

DECOMPOSITION PATTERN 1: INFORMATION -> STRUCTURE -> CONTENT The most broadly applicable pattern. Works for almost any document.

Stage 1, Information gathering "Extract all the relevant information from [source(s)]." -> Output: Raw material, structured as a list

Stage 2, Structure design "Given this information, propose a document structure. What are the main sections? What is the most logical order? What is the key argument or narrative?" -> Output: Document structure with brief section notes

[Human review: Adjust structure before committing to draft]

Stage 3, Draft "Draft [Document X] using the agreed structure." -> Output: Full draft

Stage 4, Review and refine (optional, Chapter 18)

This pattern works for: proposals, reports, articles, presentations, plans, briefing documents.

DECOMPOSITION PATTERN 2: CLARIFY -> EXPLORE -> RECOMMEND Most useful for analysis and decision support.

Stage 1, Clarify the question "Help me define exactly what question I need to answer. Here is the situation: [context] Here is what I'm trying to decide: [decision] What additional information would be most valuable? What are the key sub- questions?" -> Output: Sharper framing of the problem

Stage 2, Explore options and evidence "Given this framing, what are the main options or considerations? What does the evidence suggest about each?" -> Output: Analysis of options

Stage 3, Recommend "Based on what we've established, what would you recommend and why? What are the main risks of your recommendation?" -> Output: Recommendation with reasoning and risk assessment



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This pattern works for: decision preparation, strategy analysis, problem diagnosis, options assessment.

DECOMPOSITION PATTERN 3: COMPONENTS -> DRAFT EACH -> ASSEMBLE Most useful for large documents with distinct sections.

Stage 1, Define components "This document has [N] sections: [list them]. Let's draft each one separately. Start with Section 1."

Stage 2, Draft each component [For each section:] "Draft Section [N]: [title]. Key points to cover: [list]. Length: [specification]. Tone: [specification]."

Stage 3, Assemble and review "I'm going to paste in all sections now. Review them as a complete document: , Do they flow logically? , Are there repetitions or gaps? , Is the tone consistent throughout? , What would you change?"

This pattern works for: annual reports, long proposals, training materials, multi-section documents.

MAKING HANDOFFS EXPLICIT Between stages, always do two things:

- REVIEW THE OUTPUT.
- Does the output of Stage N accurately reflect what you wanted?
- Is anything missing? Is anything wrong? Correct it before it
- propagates to Stage N+1.
- CARRY FORWARD WHAT MATTERS.
- When moving to the next stage, either reference the previous
- output directly (in the same conversation, AI will remember it) or
- paste in what AI needs to know. Don't assume AI will apply

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context from Stage 1 accurately at Stage 3 if the conversation is very long.

TRY THIS TAKE A PIECE OF WORK YOU NEED TO PRODUCE IN THE NEXT WEEK. SPEND FIVE MINUTES MAPPING IT

1. What are the distinct stages this work naturally has? 2. What is the deliverable of each stage? 3. Where is human review most important, where could an error in Stage N make Stage N+1 irretrievably wrong?

Now design the workflow before you start. The map will tell you what to ask AI for at each stage.

WATCH OUT STAGES THAT ARE TOO GRANULAR CREATE OVERHEAD WITHOUT BENEFIT. IF YOU FIND YOURSELF DOING TEN

each stage produces something that can be reviewed and corrected before the next stage begins. If a stage is so small that there's nothing meaningful to review, combine it with the adjacent stage.



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